Climate, Wildlife, Animal Science, and Clean Tech: The Week of September 13–19, 2026

This week's dominant story was federal: the EPA finalized the repeal of carbon pollution limits for coal and gas power plants and proposed abandoning climate regulation of the power sector altogether. Elsewhere, a cross-border wildlife corridor earned international recognition, a Mumbai veterinarian's own hospital stay illustrated a growing public-health risk, and a Texas battery developer announced more than a billion dollars in financing. Sourcing is noted throughout, since several items rely on claims from advocacy groups or single reports rather than settled fact.

Climate Policy

EPA repeals power plant carbon standards, proposes to exit climate regulation entirely. On September 14, at a G20 energy ministers' meeting in Houston, EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin signed a final rule repealing most of the 2024 Carbon Pollution Standards — the Biden-era rule that had required coal- and gas-fired power plants to control greenhouse gas emissions, in some cases via carbon capture technology. The same day, EPA issued a supplemental proposal going further: it would rescind all remaining greenhouse gas standards for power plants and formally conclude that the agency lacks authority to regulate power-sector GHG emissions at all under Section 111 of the Clean Air Act. The public comment period on that proposal runs through November 2. EPA says the partial repeal alone will save an estimated $310 billion between 2026 and 2047; environmental groups call the move a wholesale abdication of the agency's mission. The action follows the EPA's earlier repeal of the 2009 "endangerment finding" — the scientific basis for regulating greenhouse gases as a public health threat — and adds a new legal wrinkle to *Suncor Energy v. Boulder County*, a case over state tort liability for climate damages headed to Supreme Court oral argument on October 5.

Virginia's governor moves to rein in data centers. Governor Abigail Spanberger signed an executive order this week establishing a data center accountability framework for the Commonwealth, according to Virginia LCV and a copy of the order posted by her office. The framework bans non-disclosure agreements covering data center deals, sets water-use and noise regulations, requires data centers to pay their fair share of transmission and generation costs, limits new gas-fired generation built to power them, and makes it easier for data centers to bring their own clean power. Virginia hosts the largest concentration of data centers in the world, and rising electricity demand from them has become a flashpoint in utility rate cases nationally.

Congress's closing moves before recess. Ahead of an extended recess, the House narrowly passed two Congressional Review Act resolutions rolling back ship-engine air pollution and efficiency standards, and passed the Ratepayer Protection Act — a bill that encourages, but does not require, states to shield ratepayers from data center-driven cost increases. League of Conservation Voters, an advocacy group, criticized both moves as favoring fossil fuel and tech interests

over consumers; that characterization reflects the group's political position rather than a neutral summary of the bills' content. Separately, congressional Democrats held a press conference this week criticizing the Trump administration over roughly $4 billion in cumulative offshore wind lease buyouts made over previous months — payments the administration has directed, in some cases, toward LNG export investment instead. The $4 billion figure reflects total spending accumulated since spring, independently confirmed by multiple wire-service reports over the summer; this week's news was the congressional criticism, not new spending.

Wildlife & Conservation

- **A massive wildlife corridor was named a finalist for a major environmental prize.** The Yellowstone to Yukon Conservation Initiative (Y2Y) — a 30-year-old effort connecting protected habitat along a 3,400-kilometer stretch of the Rocky Mountains from Wyoming to Canada's Yukon — was named the first-ever Canadian finalist for Prince William's Earthshot Prize, in the "Protect and Restore Nature" category, CBC News and CP24 reported September 18–19. The corridor spans five U.S. states, two Canadian provinces and territories, and more than 75 Indigenous territories, and has supported over 200 wildlife crossings that help species like grizzly bears, wolverines, and caribou move safely across roads. Winners of the prize's five categories, each receiving roughly $1.9 million (CAD) to scale their work, will be announced in Mumbai in November.

Animal Health & Field Science

- **India's exotic pet trade is creating new disease-spillover risks.** In a feature published this week, Mongabay India reported on the public-health dimension of India's booming exotic pet trade, centered on Mumbai veterinarian Dr. Rina Dev, who treats imported and seized wildlife and was recently hospitalized for four days with a lung infection she suspected may have come from parrots in her care. Traded birds commonly carry avian chlamydiosis (psittacosis, "bird handler's disease"); traded reptiles carry salmonella; and traded primates carry tuberculosis and, in rare cases, pathogens like Ebola or HIV that can pass between humans and other primates due to close evolutionary kinship. A 2026 report by Humane World for Animals found that traded mammals are 1.5 times more likely to share pathogens with humans than non-traded mammals, and that on average, a species picks up one additional shared pathogen with humans for every decade it remains in trade. Conservation researchers quoted in the piece said first responders like customs officials often lack basic disease-prevention equipment during seizures, and that trafficked animals bypass quarantine procedures entirely — a gap the "One Health" framework, which treats human, animal, and environmental health as interconnected, is meant to address but hasn't yet closed in India's case.

Clean Technology

- **A major battery storage financing package was announced in Texas.** Austin-based Jupiter Power announced September 16 that it had closed $1.4

billion in financing across four separate transactions, supporting ten utility-scale battery storage projects — eight in Texas, two in Michigan — totaling 1,500 MW and 3,600 MWh of capacity. The transactions themselves closed between April and July; this week's news was Jupiter's public announcement of the completed financing, not new deals struck this week. The financing brings the company's total since its 2017 founding past $3 billion; Jupiter says it now has 5.6 GW of projects operating, under construction, or contracted, with another 23 GW in development across U.S. power markets.

- **Solar manufacturing and financing activity continued internationally**, per trade outlet Renewable Watch: India's Vikram Solar signed a 1 GW domestic solar-cell supply agreement with Avaada Electro (Sept. 16), U.S. investment firm Generate Capital secured new financing for community solar projects (Sept. 16), and European developer Econergy acquired Spanish company Escofi for €134.3 million (Sept. 16).

The Big Picture

The EPA's power plant rule is, by a wide margin, the most consequential development covered here this week — a federal agency moving not just to loosen a specific regulation but to argue it has no authority to regulate greenhouse gases from power plants at all, a stance that will likely be tested in court for years. Virginia's data center order and Congress's closing pre-recess votes both reflect a related but separate fight: who pays for the electricity demand boom driven by AI and data centers, and on what terms. Away from that federal fight, the Y2Y corridor's Earthshot nomination was a reminder that some of the most ambitious conservation work — connecting habitat across international borders over three decades — proceeds on its own timeline regardless of the federal news cycle, and the India reporting on zoonotic disease risk pointed at a quieter, structural gap between wildlife trade enforcement and public health surveillance. None of this week's threads are resolved; the EPA proposal alone will generate news well into November and beyond.

Sources

EPA power plant rule: EPA.gov, official rule pages for the Partial Repeal of the Carbon Pollution Standards and the Supplemental Proposal, Sept. 14, 2026; Federal Register publication, Sept. 17, 2026; NBC News, "EPA to repeal limits on greenhouse gas pollution from power plants," Sept. 14, 2026; Insurance Journal (Bloomberg wire, Hirji/Natter/Dlouhy), Sept. 15, 2026; National Law Review and Sidley Environmental, Health, and Safety Brief legal analyses, Sept. 15, 2026; Coal Age, Sept. 15, 2026.

Virginia data center order: Virginia LCV newsroom statement and official executive order (EO-22) posted by the Office of the Governor of Virginia; WJLA, Sept. 2026; League of Conservation Voters, "This Week in Climate Action – September 18, 2026."

Congressional action and offshore wind buyouts: League of Conservation Voters, "This Week in Climate Action – September 18, 2026"; Washington Post/AP/Courthouse News, cumulative offshore wind buyout reporting through

August 2026; Canary Media, “Trump’s $4B in offshore wind buyouts spur legal blowback from states.”

Wildlife & conservation: CBC News, “Yellowstone to Yukon Conservation Initiative is 1st Canadian finalist for Prince William’s prize,” Sept. 18, 2026; CP24, Sept. 19, 2026.

Animal health & field science: Mongabay India, “Exotic pet trade poses rising zoonotic disease risks in India” and “Your exotic pet could be putting your health at risk,” Sept. 2026, by Arathi Menon, citing a 2026 Humane World for Animals report.

Clean technology: Jupiter Power press release, Sept. 16, 2026; dbusiness.com and mgrid.org, Sept. 16, 2026; Renewable Watch, news items dated Sept. 16–17, 2026.

Note: Two items in this edition involve underlying activity from before this week — the Jupiter Power transactions (closed April–July) and the offshore wind buyout total (accumulated since spring) — while the news this week was, respectively, the public announcement and congressional criticism. Both distinctions are made explicit in the article text.

Published September 20, 2026